

ELECTED OFFICIAL BRIEFING

Mayor Brandon Johnson

City of Chicago, Illinois

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Situation

You're governing a city in the middle of a genuine political crisis of your own making — and an opportunity to turn it around. Chicago's 1.6 million registered voters rank **affordable housing** (score: 72.9) and **anti-gentrification** (score: 69.8) as their top concerns, followed closely by **school funding** (score: 68.2) and **public transit** (score: 67.6). These are issues where you have real authority and where your record offers genuine achievements. Yet your approval rating has collapsed to roughly 20%, your FY2026 budget was passed 30–18 by a council coalition acting without you, and two senior finance officials departed within weeks of each other in January 2026. The city's structural challenge — \$36+ billion in unfunded pension liabilities, a \$1.15 billion annual budget gap, and growing reliance on one-time revenue — will define whether your second half in office stabilizes or spirals.

Your First 90 Days: Top 4 Focus Areas

First, **restore fiscal credibility** by appointing a permanent, high-profile CFO and signaling a disciplined FY2027 budget process. The CFO vacancy and comptroller departure are the single most visible symbols of administrative instability — filling them decisively changes the narrative with bond markets, credit agencies, and the business community. Second, **convert the crime decline into political capital**. Chicago's 30% homicide reduction in 2025 — the city's safest year this century — is a concrete, verifiable success that constituents care about (57.3 violent crime concern score signals residual anxiety). A sustained public campaign framing this as evidence of what your administration delivers shifts the conversation from dysfunction to results. Third, **implement the ADU ordinance visibly and fast**. The unanimous 46–0 ADU vote is your most recent bipartisan win; rapid approvals and groundbreaking ceremonies on coach houses and granny flats demonstrate housing progress against constituents' #1 priority. Fourth, **engage the council budget coalition early on FY2027**. Reaching out now to Ald. Nicole Lee (11th) and Ald. Scott Waguespack (32nd) to co-develop the framework — before a crisis forces the conversation — is the only path to avoiding another December standoff.

2. LESSONS LEARNED FROM RECENT HISTORY

1. The CTU Alliance Requires Active Management, Not Just Loyalty

Your foundational labor base is also your biggest governance liability when it comes to CPS. The firing of CEO Pedro Martinez in December 2024 — engineered over his refusal to take high-interest loans to fund CTU raises during a \$500M deficit — left CPS without permanent leadership and triggered a board-vs.-City Hall crisis. The lesson: CTU's interests and CPS students' interests are not always the same, and the mayor's job is to navigate that tension, not resolve it in favor of one party by default.

2. Personnel Failures Cost More Than Policy Defeats

The Ronnie Reese firing (October 2024) and the ongoing Jason Lee controversy (OIG recommended termination in October 2025; Johnson kept him) have consumed enormous political bandwidth and reinforced narratives of insularity and poor judgment. These are not policy disputes — they are management failures. Establish clear conduct standards and enforce them swiftly; a single swift accountability decision on Jason Lee would eliminate an ongoing vulnerability.

3. Budget Transparency Prevents Council Rebellion

Presenting the FY2026 budget with a controversial corporate head tax, reduced pension payments, and aspirational 'efficiencies' — without pre-negotiating council buy-in — led to an unprecedented Finance Committee rejection (November 17, 2025) and a council-drafted budget (passed 30-18, December 20). The lesson: Chicago's council has discovered its independence. Budget proposals must be negotiated, not presented. Begin FY2027 outreach to key alderpersons by March 2026.

4. Genuine Policy Wins Exist — But Need to Be Communicated

The 46-0 ADU expansion vote (September 2025), the 30% homicide reduction (best year this century), and the successful DNC hosting (August 2024, \$371M economic impact) are real achievements that have been overshadowed by the budget wars and personnel controversies. Your communications operation needs to consistently elevate these wins so constituents and media have a balanced picture of governance.

5. Governing Narrow Wins Differently Than Running Them

You won office 52.2%–47.8% on a grassroots coalition and have continued to govern toward that coalition. But citywide governance requires consistent engagement with at least 26 of 50 alderpersons. The Welcoming City vote (39–11) shows a larger coalition is available on some issues. Build on those alliances systematically rather than only when crisis demands it.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: City Council Relationship and Approval Recovery

Timing: Poll February–March 2026, before FY2027 budget season begins

Key Questions:

- What is your top concern about how the City of Chicago is being managed right now?
- On a scale of 1–10, how satisfied are you with the mayor's transparency on the city budget?
- Which city service would you most like to see protected in the 2027 budget?

Why This Matters: Budget credibility is the #1 driver of the approval collapse. Polling shows where constituents' budget priorities actually lie — letting you frame FY2027 around constituent needs rather than political fights. **Action:** Contact Good Party to set up a budget priorities poll in February 2026.

3. QUICK WINS

1 Appoint a Permanent CFO and Comptroller

- The simultaneous departure of CFO Jill Jaworski and Comptroller Chasse Rehwinkel in January 2026 sent an alarm signal to bond markets and credit agencies watching Chicago's \$36B pension liability problem. Announce a permanent CFO from outside the political sphere — someone with credible capital markets experience — within 60 days. Pair the announcement with a public FY2027 budget framework showing a structural path forward rather than reliance on one-time revenue.

2 Launch a '411 to Zero' Crime Decline Campaign

- Chicago had 411 homicides in 2025 — the fewest this century, a 30% year-over-year decline, and the safest summer since 1965. This is a genuine, verifiable success story that your constituents' data shows they care about (57.3 violent crime concern score). Convene a press conference with Superintendent Snelling, community violence interrupters, and Peacekeepers program leaders. Partner with WBEZ and local TV on an accountability story about what's working. Challenge national media using outdated Chicago crime narratives to update their coverage with 2025 data.

3 Accelerate ADU Implementation — Make It Visible

- The unanimous 46–0 ADU ordinance (September 2025, effective April 1, 2026) legalizes coach houses, basement units, and attic apartments citywide. Constituents' top issue is affordable housing (score: 72.9). Stand up a fast-track ADU permitting process in the Department of Buildings before the April 1 effective date. Announce the first permits issued on opening day. Schedule ribbon-cuttings for first completed coach houses as a visible housing win.

4 Resolve the CPS CEO Search — Announce Before Spring

- The Chicago Public Schools CEO vacancy has become a symbol of governance dysfunction, with the school board publicly accusing City Hall of 'sabotage' in the search process. Constituents rank school funding as their third highest priority (score: 68.2). Remove any administration interference, let the board conduct an independent search, and celebrate a strong permanent appointment as a stabilizing moment for the city's children.

5 Reach Out to Budget Coalition Leaders Before March 15

- The 30–18 council budget coalition (led by Ald. Lee and Waguespack) represents the new reality of Chicago City Council. Request one-on-one meetings with all coalition members to begin FY2027 framework discussions. Bring OBM Director Annette Guzman to demonstrate fiscal seriousness. A joint statement with even three or four coalition members about shared budget priorities would signal a break from the 2025–2026 cycle of last-minute warfare.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: ADU / Affordable Housing Policy Priorities

Timing: Poll March 15–31, 2026 (before ADU ordinance takes effect April 1)

Key Questions:

- Would you consider adding a rental unit (coach house, basement apt) to your property?
- What is the biggest barrier to affordable housing in your neighborhood?

- Should the city invest more in renter protections, new construction, or both?

Why This Matters: Constituents' #1 issue is housing (score: 72.9), and the ADU win is real — but you need to know what housing TYPE they want next. Polling shapes your FY2027 housing investment priorities with evidence. **Action:** Contact Good Party to set up a housing priorities poll before April 1.

4. YOUR CONSTITUENTS' TOP ISSUES

Data drawn from L2/Haystaq voter file for the City of Chicago, Illinois. Analysis covers 1,644,715 matched voter records. Scores represent 0–100 predictive indexes; only issues within mayoral and city council authority are included below.

Demographics at a Glance

Metric	Value
Total Registered Voters	1,677,604
Average Age	47.8 years
Male	782,351 (46.6%)
Female	895,078 (53.4%)

Top Issues by Priority (Local/City Authority Only)

Rank	Issue	Score	Tier
1	Affordable Housing (Government Role)	72.9	Strong
2	Anti-Gentrification / Displacement	69.8	Strong
3	School Funding (More Investment)	68.2	Strong
4	Public Transit Support	67.6	Strong
5	Climate / Environment Believer	67.1	Strong
6	Social Services / Helping People	66.7	Strong
7	Environmental Policy Priority	62.0	Strong
8	Infrastructure Investment	58.8	Moderate
9	Violent Crime Concern	57.3	Moderate
10	Economic Development Priority	48.0	Low

Tier guide: Critical 75+ | Strong 60–74 | Moderate 50–59 | Low <50. Federal issues excluded (healthcare, immigration enforcement, abortion, etc.)

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: Housing Type Preference (Score 72.9 — Strong, but direction unclear)

Timing: March–April 2026, before FY2027 housing budget decisions

Key Questions:

- Chicago residents strongly support government action on housing — but WHAT kind? Rent control, new construction subsidies, or tenant protections?
- Gentrification opposition score is 69.8. Which neighborhoods do residents feel most need anti-displacement investment?

Why This Matters: Haystaq shows strong housing concern but can't tell you which specific mechanisms constituents want. Polling provides the mandate for specific policy choices. **Action:** Contact Good Party to set up a housing priorities poll.

5. WHAT TO WATCH & PREPARE FOR

Issues Requiring Immediate Attention

- **CFO / Comptroller Vacancies (Now)** — Both the Chief Financial Officer (Jaworski, departed Jan. 2026) and City Comptroller (Rehwinkel, departed for Devon Bank) positions are vacant or in transition as the city enters a critical fiscal year. Credit agencies are watching. A permanent appointment signals stabilization; continued vacancy signals drift.
- **CPS CEO Vacancy and School Board Conflict (Now)** — The Chicago Public Schools board — now partly elected — has publicly accused City Hall of sabotaging the CEO search. A CPS without permanent leadership heading into CTU contract negotiations is an institutional risk to the school system serving 340,000 students, your constituents' third-highest priority (school funding score: 68.2).
- **Federal Funding Freeze (Now, ongoing)** — The Trump administration froze approximately \$10B in social service funding for Illinois in January 2026. Chicago depends on federal dollars for transit (CTA), housing vouchers, education Title I funds, and social services. Legal challenges are pending but outcomes are uncertain; the city should have contingency budgets ready for each major federal funding stream by March 2026.

Political Dynamics to Understand

- **The 30–18 Budget Coalition** — Alderpersons Nicole Lee (11th) and Scott Waguespack (32nd) led a council majority to pass its own budget over your objections in December 2025 — the first time in modern Chicago history a mayor's budget was overridden. This coalition is now emboldened. They must be engaged as partners, not opponents, for FY2027 to avoid another December crisis.
- **The CTU Factor** — The Chicago Teachers Union is your base, your campaign engine, and your most complicated governance relationship. CTU's contract expires in 2026–2027; expect early negotiations and significant financial demands. How you handle the tension between CTU interests and CPS fiscal stability will define the second half of your term.
- **2027 Mayoral Field** — At least six credible challengers are circling, led by Alexi Giannoulias (\$5.9M war chest) and potential entry by Mike Quigley (Congressional incumbent). Your campaign has \$829,764 — a significant gap. Every governance decision from now through July 2026 doubles as campaign positioning.

Upcoming Challenges & Decisions

- **FY2027 Budget (Begin March 2026, adopt December 2026)** — Chicago's structural gap is estimated at \$700M–\$1B again for FY2027. The reduced advance pension payment in FY2026 compounded the long-term liability. Begin outreach to the council budget coalition now. Present a structural — not one-time — revenue and expense framework.
- **CTU Contract Negotiations (2026–2027)** — The existing CTU contract terms and CPS financial situation make the next negotiation high-stakes. CPS's FY2025 deficit is approximately \$500M. Any new contract with significant raises requires a credible funding plan that doesn't rely on unsustainable borrowing.
- **2027 Reelection Decision (Deadline: Summer 2026)** — Petition circulation for the February 23, 2027 mayoral election must begin by summer 2026. A decision to run requires a viable fundraising strategy against opponents with multimillion-dollar war chests. A decision not to run requires managing lame-duck dynamics while still governing. This decision cannot be deferred past June 2026.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: FY2027 Budget Priorities

Timing: April–May 2026, before budget season begins in earnest

Key Questions:

- If the city faces a \$1B budget gap, which services would you prioritize protecting?
- Would you support a modest property tax increase to fund pension obligations?
- Which new revenue source would you find most and least acceptable?

Why This Matters: The budget coalition passed its own budget because the mayor didn't build constituent-mandate pressure behind specific revenue choices. Polling gives you constituent evidence to present to alderpersons when negotiating FY2027.

Action: Contact Good Party to set up a budget priorities poll by April 2026.

6. UNDERSTANDING THE ROLE OF MAYOR

What Is Expected of This Role

Chicago operates under a **strong-mayor, city council** form of government — one of the most powerful mayoral systems in the United States. The mayor is the chief executive: you appoint all department heads (with council consent), control the budget proposal, set the legislative agenda, and are the public face of city government. The City Council (50 alderpersons) is the legislative body — it appropriates funds, passes ordinances, and must confirm major appointments. There is no city manager; operational authority runs directly through the mayor's office.

In practice, Chicago's model gives the mayor extraordinary agenda-setting power, but the FY2026 budget rebellion showed that a determined council majority can exercise its formal appropriation authority independently. Your executive authority is real and substantial — but it requires consistent, active coalition management with at least 26 of 50 alderpersons to govern effectively.

What Is Outside the Scope of This Role

The mayor does not directly manage schools — Chicago Public Schools has its own board (now partly elected under the 2021 reform law) and CEO. You appoint a portion of the board, which creates influence, but CPS governance is constitutionally and operationally separate. Similarly, Cook County government (county courts, county jail, county health system) operates independently; federal policy on immigration, healthcare, and national defense is outside your authority, even when it directly affects city residents.

How to Represent Your Community

Chicago is a city of 77 distinct community areas with dramatically different demographic, economic, and political profiles. Governing well means balancing the West Side constituents who elected you against the North Shore ward alderpersons whose votes you need for any legislation. Use constituent data — like the Haystaq scores in this briefing — to understand what the broader, silent electorate actually cares about, not just the organized advocates who show up to meetings.

Transparency and responsiveness are your most cost-effective tools. When constituents feel heard — through real polling, accessible town halls, and honest communication about difficult tradeoffs — they extend more goodwill for necessary compromises. Good Party's polling capability offers a direct channel to gauge constituent opinion before major decisions, rather than relying on public comment (which systematically overrepresents organized groups).

7. TOP 3 BUDGET DISCUSSIONS (Aug 2025 – Feb 2026)

#1 — Johnson's FY2026 Revenue Package Rejected by Finance Committee | Nov. 17, 2025

- Mayor's package included a \$21/employee/month 'corporate head tax' on large employers, projected to raise ~\$100M annually as part of a \$600M revenue package to close a \$1.15B corporate fund gap (Chicago Tribune, Nov. 17, 2025).
- Finance Committee voted down the package; a motion to delay failed on an 18–18 tie — the first time in modern memory a mayor's budget plan was blocked in committee (Block Club Chicago, Nov. 17, 2025).
- Overall proposed budget: \$17.3B for FY2026 (Chicago Sun-Times, Nov. 17, 2025).

Outcome: Budget crisis triggered weeks of standoff and government shutdown threat.

Why This Matters for You: The head tax was politically isolated from the start — no council pre-negotiation, no business community buy-in. FY2027 cannot repeat this pattern. Begin revenue discussions with council and stakeholders by March 2026.

#2 — City Council Passes Rival FY2026 Budget Without Mayor's Signature | Dec. 19–20, 2025

- Council passed a \$16.6B record budget (revenue vote 29–19 on Dec. 19; spending vote 30–18 on Dec. 20) in a rare Saturday session (WTTW, Dec. 20, 2025).
- Alternative revenue: social media tax, higher cloud computing tax, liquor tax, expanded congestion tax on rideshares, increased plastic bag tax and fines — replacing the rejected head tax (Block Club Chicago, Dec. 20, 2025).
- Advance pension payment cut from planned \$238M to \$120.2M, raising concerns from credit agencies and fiscal watchdogs (Civic Federation).

Outcome: Johnson allowed budget to take effect without signing or vetoing — a historic rebuke.

Why This Matters for You: The reduced pension advance is a ticking clock. Every year of underfunding adds compound liability. The FY2027 budget must include a credible path toward restoring advance payments to avoid credit downgrades.

#3 — CFO Jaworski and Comptroller Rehwinkel Depart Simultaneously | Jan. 7, 2026

- CFO Jill Jaworski announced departure to Navy Pier; Comptroller Chasse Rehwinkel had already announced departure to Devon Bank (Chicago Tribune, Jan. 7, 2026).
- Jaworski and team managed \$16.6B city budget and \$6B+ bond portfolio; their departure raised alarms with bond markets monitoring Chicago's pension exposure (Bond Buyer, Jan. 2026).
- Steven Mahr named interim CFO; permanent appointment pending (Chicago Tribune, Dec. 23, 2024).

Outcome: City entered new fiscal year with interim finance leadership and no permanent CFO.

Why This Matters for You: Bond markets price uncertainty into borrowing costs. A swift, credible permanent CFO appointment is the single fastest action available to stabilize financial perceptions of the administration.

8. TOP 3 NON-BUDGET POLICY DISCUSSIONS (Aug 2025 – Feb 2026)

#1 — Citywide ADU (Accessory Dwelling Unit) Expansion | Sept. 25, 2025 | Vote: 46–0

- Council unanimously approved Ord. SO2024-0008918 legalizing coach houses, basement apartments, and attic units citywide, with alderpersons retaining opt-in rights for single-family zones (WTTW, Sept. 25, 2025).
- Effective April 1, 2026; requires union apprentice labor for construction (Block Club Chicago, Sept. 25, 2025).
- Championed by the mayor and Ald. Bennett Lawson (44th); one of the rare unanimous council votes under the Johnson administration.

Outcome: Bipartisan housing win; ordinance takes effect April 1, 2026.

Why This Matters for You: Constituents' top priority is housing (72.9). Rapid, visible implementation of ADU permitting by April 1 converts a legislative win into tangible results. This is your highest-potential early win.

#2 — Inspector General Independence Ordinance | July 16, 2025 | Overwhelming Majority

- Council passed Ord. SO2025-0015583 protecting the OIG from administration interference in investigations, limiting attorney presence at OIG interviews and clarifying OIG access to privileged records (OIG Press Release, July 17, 2025).
- IG Deborah Witzburg announced she would not seek a second term after securing protections, stating she leaves OIG 'better and stronger' (WTTW, July 17, 2025).
- Passed amid ongoing controversy over senior advisor Jason Lee's refusal to cooperate with OIG investigation (OIG later recommended Lee's firing in October 2025; Johnson retained him) (WTTW, Oct. 15, 2025).

Outcome: OIG protections codified; Johnson's retention of Jason Lee remains unresolved vulnerability.

Why This Matters for You: The Jason Lee controversy reinforces a narrative of insularity that directly feeds the approval collapse. A swift resolution — consistent with the spirit of the OIG independence ordinance the council just passed — would remove a persistent wound.

#3 — Welcoming City Ordinance Defense Against Federal Pressure | Jan. 15, 2025 | Vote: 39–11

- Two alderpersons introduced a measure to allow CPD cooperation with federal immigration enforcement in certain criminal cases; Council voted 39–11 to table (block) the measure and preserve sanctuary status (WTTW, Jan. 15, 2025).
- Trump administration has threatened to withhold federal funding from sanctuary cities throughout 2025–2026 (WBEZ, Jan. 15, 2025).
- Chicago's federal funding exposure includes CTA transit grants, HUD housing vouchers, Title I school funding, and social service contracts — all potentially at risk from the Trump administration's funding freeze announced January 2026.

Outcome: Sanctuary status preserved 39–11; federal funding threat remains live through 2026.

Why This Matters for You: The 39–11 vote shows a large council majority on your side on this issue. But the financial exposure is real — develop contingency budgets for each major federal funding stream and maintain the legal challenges as the primary line of defense.

9. APPENDIX: KEY RESOURCES

Resource	Details / URL
City of Chicago	chicago.gov
Mayor's Office	chicago.gov/city/en/depts/mayor.html
2026 Adopted Budget	chicityclerk.com/2026-chicago-city-budget
Office of Budget & Management	chicago.gov/city/en/depts/obm.html
City Council Meetings Archive	chicityclerkelms.chicago.gov/Meetings/
Chicago Councilmatic (Legislation)	chicago.councilmatic.org
Chicago Data Portal	data.cityofchicago.org
Office of Inspector General	igchicago.org
Civic Federation (Fiscal Analysis)	civicfed.org
2027 Election Date	February 23, 2027 (petition circulation: summer 2026)
Key Contacts	Name / Role
Mayor	Brandon Johnson (inaugurated May 15, 2023)
Chief of Staff	Rich Guidice
Budget Director (OBM)	Annette Guzman
CFO (interim)	Steven Mahr
Police Superintendent	Larry Snelling
City Clerk	Anna Valencia
City Treasurer	Melissa Conyears-Ervin
FY2026 Total Budget	\$16.6 billion (record)
FY2026 Corporate Fund Gap Closed	\$1.15 billion
Advance Pension Payment (FY2026)	\$120.2M (reduced from planned \$238M)
Unfunded Pension Liability (all 4 funds)	\$36+ billion
2025 Homicides	411 (30% year-over-year decline; century low)